Gender Roles

What are Gender roles

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(Understanding the term "gender roles" requires an understanding of the term "gender" is a social term that is often confused with the term "sex:' Sex and gender are different concepts. Sex is a biological concept, determined on the basis of individuals' primary sex characteristics. Gender, on the other hand, refers to the meanings, values, and characteristics that people ascribe to different sexes.)

Ann Oakley (1972) was one the first social scientists to distinguish the concept of gender from the concept of sex. According to Oakley, gender parallels the biological division of sex into male and female, but it involves the division and social valuation of masculinity and femininity. In other words, gender is a concept that humans create socially, through their interactions with one another and their environments, yet it relies heavily upon biological differences between males and females. Because humans create the concept of gender socially, gender is referred to as a

social construction. The social construction of gender is demonstrated by the fact that individuals, groups, and societies ascribe/attribute particular traits, statuses, or values to individuals purely because of their sex, yet these ascriptions/attributions differ across societies and cultures, and over time within the same society.

Gender roles are the roles that men and women are expected to occupy based on their sex

Traditional View of gender roles

Traditionally, many Western societies have believed that women are more nurturing than men. Therefore, the traditional view of the feminine gender role prescribes that women should behave in ways that are nurturing. One way that a woman might engage in the traditional feminine gender role would be to nurture her family by working full-time **within the home** rather than taking employment outside of the home. Men, on the other hand, are presumed by traditional views of gender roles to be leaders. The traditional view of the masculine gender role, therefore, suggests that men should be the heads of their households by providing financially for the family and making important family decisions. While these views remain dominant in many spheres of society, alternative perspectives on traditional beliefs about gender roles have gained increasing support in the twenty-first century.

Men therefore were considered responsible for taking care of the family financially. They took their jobs as sole providers very seriously. They also had the responsibility for guiding the family. While they may listen to what their wives had to say, they made the final decisions. Men did not do household duties or childcare. They felt the need to be strong and refrained from showing too much emotion or sharing too many personal feelings, especially with those outside of the family.

Women were expected to be in charge of running the household. Mothers did the laundry, cooked the meals, and cleaned the rooms. They also took care of the children, giving them the care and attention that was required.

The wealthier families might hire a nanny, and childcare became more widely used in the later 20th century. But the women were often in charge of directing the nannies and dropping off or picking up from daycare. Women were seen as more emotional than men, more likely and more encouraged to open up about their feelings.

3.3 Different disciplines and their perspectives on gender roles.

Different disciplines offer a range of perspectives on gender roles.

- ✓ An **ecological perspective** on gender roles suggests that gender roles are created by the interactions between individuals, communities, and their environments. That is, while individual people play a role in constructing gender roles, so too do the physical and social environments within which people operate.
- ✓ A **biological perspective** on gender roles suggests that women have a natural affinity toward the feminine gender role and that men have a natural affinity toward the masculine gender role. The biological perspective does not, however, suggest that one role holds any inherently greater value than another role.
- ✓ A **sociological perspective** toward gender roles suggests that masculine and feminine roles are learned and that masculine and feminine gender roles are not necessarily connected to males' and females' biological traits. Sociologists study the different meanings and values that masculine and feminine gender roles hold in society.

- ✓ Related to the sociological perspective, **a feminist perspective** on gender roles might assert that because gender roles are learned, they can also be unlearned, and that new and different roles can be created. The feminist perspective points out that these gender roles are not simply ideas about appropriate behavior for males and females but are also linked to the different levels of power that males and females hold in society. For example, maintaining economic control over themselves and their families is one way that men experience greater power in society than women. Because men are expected to be the primary breadwinners for their families, women often find themselves to be in poverty if their marriages dissolve. In this example, a feminist perspective would assert that men tend to hold more power in their marriages than women since men are less likely to lose power or social status if their marriages dissolve.

3.4 Gender roles and the work place

Gender roles can be linked to expectations of males and females in realms outside of the family as well, such as work (Williams 1995). In the workplace, men and women are often expected to perform different tasks and occupy different roles based on their sex (Kanter 1977).

Even in the early twenty-first century, many corporations operate from a perspective that favors traditional beliefs about gender roles by, for example, offering parental leave benefits only to mothers and denying such benefits to fathers. In addition, because the traditional perspective toward gender roles remains predominant in many corporations, the positions that women and men hold within corporations are often segregated by sex. Women are more likely to be expected to work as secretaries, and men are more likely to be expected to work as managers

and executives. Also, men are presumed to be more ambitious and task-oriented in their work, while women are presumed to be more interested in and concerned about their relationships with others at work.

3.5 How gender roles are created

As these examples demonstrate, gender roles are sometimes created on **the basis of stereotypes about gender.** *Gender stereotypes are oversimplified understandings of males and females and the differences between them. Individuals sometimes base their perceptions about appropriate gender roles upon gender stereotypes. Gender stereotypes tend to include exaggerated or erroneous assertions about the nature of males and females. For example, a common gender stereotype about males is that they are not emotional. Females, on the other hand, are commonly stereotyped as being irrational or overly emotional. Political movements such as the feminist movement continue to work to deconstruct gender stereotypes and offer alternative visions of gender roles that emphasize equality between women and men.*

Finally, gender roles are often discussed in terms of an **individual's gender role orientation, which is typically described as either traditional or nontraditional.** A **traditional** gender role orientation emphasizes differences between men and women and assumes that each sex has a natural affinity to particular behaviors. Those who maintain a traditional gender role orientation are likely to be influenced by the rules and rituals of the generations that came before them, by their parents and grandparents. **Individuals with nontraditional** gender role orientations are more likely to believe that an individual's behavior is not or should not be determined solely by her sex. Individuals with nontraditional gender role orientations are more likely to believe in the value of egalitarian relationships (In an egalitarian relationship, partners share

responsibilities, benefits, and burdens equally, fostering a partnership where both have a voice and contribute equally to the relationship's success) between men and women and in the power of individual human beings to determine what roles they wish to occupy and the extent to which those roles are or should be associated with their sex.

Gender roles are **passed on through generations**. From the age of three, children are able to start becoming aware of the differences between girls and boys based on the actions of the parents and the nature of their environment.

- Lucy may continually be dressed in pink, purple, and flowery outfits while her brother, Jack, is given blue and gray ones.
- When Lucy is at kindergarten and picks up a truck to play with, her teacher may say, 'That's for boys. I'll go get you a girl toy.'

As the children grow a few years, they start learning what behavior is appropriate and expected.

- Lucy notices her mother cooks for the family, so she pretends to cook for her dolls.
- Jack gets a toy lawn mower to use in the den, so he can be like his daddy.

The behavior is **reinforced** when the parents praise or reward their children for their actions. They can also be punished and challenged to change, if it's considered inappropriate.

- When Lucy pretends to cook, her mother may tell her, 'That's great Lucy, one day you will be a great cook for your family.'
- Conversely, when Lucy takes a toy from Jack and he starts crying, his father may tell him, 'Now, Jack, stop that. Boys don't cry.'

Children are also encouraged to serve different roles in their interactions with the outside world. Boys are often encouraged to exert themselves in physical activity, and girls are typically given more attention to how they look and present themselves

Theories of Gender Role Development

1. Social Learning Theory

Social learning theory, most closely associated with the work of psychologist Albert Bandura, is an outgrowth of the behaviorist tradition, which defines learning in terms of stimulus and response.

According to this perspective, children are **reinforced – both positively and negatively –** for gender appropriate and inappropriate behavior (Burn, 1996; Wharton, 2005). A young boy playing with dolls, for example, might be ignored by his father; the lack of attention serves as a negative reinforcement, so that the boy eventually stops playing with dolls altogether.

Or, parents might hug a young girl who cries – the hug serving as a positive reinforcement – thereby increasing the likelihood the girl will cry again in the future. In this way, the theory suggests, boys and girls learn which behaviors are expected of them. Boys learn that playing with dolls is 'inappropriate'; girls learn that expressing emotion is consistent with being female. Social learning theory also suggests that children learn by **observing and imitating** the behavior of same-sex adults. A young girl learns what it means to be female by observing her

mother, whereas a boy learns what it means to be male by observing his father.

First proposed in the 1950s and 1960s, social learning theory has not withstood the test of time. Research has shown, for example, that parents who themselves exhibit sex stereotypical behaviors are not more likely than other parents to have children who exhibit strong sex stereotypical behaviors, thus discrediting the idea that children imitate same-sex adults (Stockard, 1999). In addition, children – and especially boys – display gender appropriate behaviors even in the absence of reinforcement (Wharton, 2005). Finally, evidence is mixed with regard to the extent to which parents reinforce male and female children differently. All of which suggests, critics argue, that children are more actively engaged in their socialization than the theory acknowledges. Wharton (2005) writes, "To simplify somewhat, we can say that social learning theory tends to view children (and other targets of socialization) as **lumps of clay that are modeled by their environment**" (p. 32).

2. Cognitive Development Theory

Cognitive theories of gender socialization offer a different perspective, emphasizing the developmental nature of the socialization process, as well as the active role the child plays in the construction of his or her gender identity (Stockard, 1999). Lawrence Kohlberg, best known for his theory of moral development, was one of the first to apply theories of cognitive development to gender identity. Specifically, he argued that "children's views of appropriate gender roles ...change as they grow older, reflecting their changing cognitive development" (Stockard, 1999,

p. 218). Younger children between the ages of five and eight tend to have the most rigid definitions of gender, and apply the most severe sanctions for violations of gender norms. As they age, however, children are able to develop more complex and flexible definitions of gender (Martin & Ruble, 2004). In general, however, Kohlberg believed that once children develop gender constancy – the recognition of themselves as male or female and the stable, unchanging nature of their gender – they become more motivated to demonstrate gender appropriate behavior (Wharton, 2005).

Critics of Kohlberg's theory pointed to contradictory evidence – the fact that children demonstrate gender-typed behavior as young as two or three years of age, long before they develop gender constancy – to discredit his theory (Martin & Ruble, 2004). They also argued that Kohlberg's theory failed to explain why children use gender, rather than some other construct, to organize their view of the world (Wharton, 2005).

3. Gender Schema Theory

In response, Sandra Bem introduced a second cognitive theory of gender socialization known as gender schema theory. According to Bem, in cultures where distinctions between men and women are emphasized, children learn to use gender as a way to process information about the world. The cognitive structures, or gender schemas, help children

organize information, and maintain a sense of consistency and predictability (Stockard, 1999).

For Bem, two characteristics of gender schemas are particularly noteworthy. She argues that gender schemas tend to be polarized, so that children believe “what is acceptable and appropriate for females is not acceptable or appropriate for males (and vice versa)” (Wharton, 2005, p. 34). And secondly, gender schemas tend to be androcentric; that is, children internalize the message that males and masculinity are the standard or norm, and are more highly valued than females and femininity (Wharton, 2005).

4. Psychoanalytic Theory

Psychoanalytic theory differs from both social learning and cognitive developmental theories in two important respects; it isn’t a learning theory, and it suggests that some aspects of gender identity result from unconscious psychological processes, rather than more conscious processes such as modeling or actively seeking information consistent with schemas (Wharton, 2005). The psychoanalytic approach was founded by Sigmund Freud, but its application to gender socialization was more fully outlined in the late 1970s by Nancy Chodorow. For Chodorow, the key factor in the development of gender identity is the role of the mother as the primary caregiver (Stockard, 1999). Because

children spend more time with mothers than fathers, Chodorow argues, their first identification is with the feminine. Eventually, however, children need to develop a sense of themselves as separate, as individual identities. For girls, the process is easier because by identifying with the mother she has already learned how to be female. Boys however, in developing a male gender identity, must first reject their identification with the feminine. “Because the boy knows most intimately what is feminine,” Stockard (1999) writes, “he comes to define masculine as being ‘not feminine’” (p. 222). In the process of separation, boys often learn to devalue femininity as well. The psychoanalytic theory, like other socialization theories, has not escaped criticism. Gender scholars argue that it’s difficult to verify empirically, that it reinforces gender stereotypes – that women seek connection, whereas men prefer separation, for example – and that it places too much emphasis on the unconscious (Wharton, 2005).

GENDER AS A SOCIAL CONSTRUCT

Judith Butler and Gender Performativity

Judith Butler is one of the most prominent social theorists currently working on issues pertaining to the social construction of gender. Butler is a trained philosopher and has oriented her work towards feminism and queer theory. Butler's most known work is *Gender Trouble: Feminism and the Subversion of Identity*, published in 1991, which argues

for gender performativity. This means that gender is not an essential category. The repetitious performances of "male" and "female" in accordance with social norms reifies the categories, creating the appearance of a naturalized and essential binary. Gender is never a stable descriptor of an individual, but an individual is always **"doing" gender**, performing or deviating from the socially accepted performance of gender stereotypes.

Doing gender is not just about acting in a particular way. It is about embodying and believing certain gender norms and engaging in practices that map on to those norms. These performances normalize the essentialism of gender categories. In other words, by doing gender, we reinforce the notion that there are only two mutually exclusive categories of gender. The internalized belief that men and women are essentially different is what makes men and women behave in ways that appear essentially different. Gender is maintained as a category through socially constructed displays of gender.

Doing gender is fundamentally a social relationship. One does gender in order to be perceived by others in a particular way, either as male, female, or as troubling those categories. Certainly, gender is internalized and acquires significance for the individual; some individuals want to feel feminine or masculine. Social constructionists might argue that

because categories are only formed within a social context, even the affect of gender is in some ways a social relation. Moreover, we hold ourselves and each other for our presentation of gender, or how we "measure up." We are aware that others evaluate and characterize our behavior on the parameter of gender. Social constructionists would say that gender is interactional rather than individual—it is developed through social interactions. Gender is also said to be omnirelevant, meaning that people are always judging our behavior to be either male or female

Gender as a "socially constructed category"

Our conception of what women and men are and what they are supposed to be is produced by the society in which we live. Thus many people say that gender is "socially constructed". The day-to-day, continuous production of gender has been called doing gender (West/Zimmermann, 1987), meaning that gender is "made" by us in everyday lives in our interactions with others. Processes of doing gender are not only carried on in our society by individuals, but also through socially-standardizing practices such as legislation or the institutions of the family and marriage. "Doing gender" thrives on continually establishing a dual order of two sexes. At the latest after birth, and often even before, people are divided into two sex categories – boy or girl. From these categories, gender characteristics are derived, like blue and pink..... In the course of her or his life, the human being is then "made" into a girl or woman or a boy or man in a complex process of rearing and education, social norms and values, stereotypes, identification, images and traditions.

What is noticeable is that conceptions of women and men are subject

to change over time. What is supposed to be feminine or masculine is historically defined. What is more important, however, that the one same difference is put forward time and again, and for this reason alone becomes important. The differentiation into two sexes is politically relevant, because evaluations are linked with it, which assign different modes of action to the genders.

On the other hand, it is often the case that it is not the one difference between the sexes which is most decisive, but that other social differences are far more important. It can be assumed today that women and men are not homogeneous groups, but that differences within the groups of women and of men can often become relevant. For instance, the social status or ethnic origin or skin colour can be a deciding factor for people who then also differentiate according to gender. On the other hand, clear-cut inequalities between women and men are hardly effective any more. In other words, it is not a matter of two colours, but of the entire colour spectrum. Modern medical definitions of gender are also multidimensional. Gender is defined in the standard (German) medical work in five dimensions; chromosomal, genital, mental and social. It is pointed out that there is a broad area of overlap in behavioural tendencies between the genders.
Deviations from the two-gender norm, such as “transsexuality” or “intersexuality” are medically classified, however, according to the International Classification of Diseases (ICD 10) as gender identity disorders. People affected by these conditions, however, experience the unambiguous classification into woman or man as social compulsion and discrimination. Intersexuals, previously called hermaphrodites, possess both male and female physical attributes. In one out of every two thousand births, the sex of a new-born baby cannot be unambiguously determined. Since the 1950s gender assignment operations have been

carried out on infants and children in which ambiguous genitals are changed surgically to fit in with traditional conceptions of female or male genitalia. Transsexuals have unambiguous physical attributes, but do not feel that they belong to the gender represented by their bodies.

“Transidentities” are scientifically discussed and researched in Queer Studies. Queer Theory sets itself the task of analyzing and questioning social discourses of normality concerning sex, gender and sexuality. The beginnings of Queer Theory are closely connected with movements in social politics which have the aim of de-pathologizing people with a transgender identity and are fighting for diversity in gender lifestyles

Gender at Work

The family picture is on HIS desk. Ah, a solid, responsible family man.

The family picture is on HER desk. Umm, her family will come before her career.

HIS desk is cluttered (disorderly). He's obviously a hard worker and a busy man.

HER desk is cluttered. She's obviously a disorganized scatterbrain.

HE is talking with his co-workers. He must be discussing the latest deal.

SHE is talking with her co-workers. She must be gossiping.

HE's not at his desk. He must be at a meeting. SHE's not at her desk. She must be in the ladies' room.

HE's having lunch with the boss. He's on his way up. SHE's having lunch with the boss. They must be having an affair.

The boss criticized HIM. He'll improve his performance. The boss criticized HER. She'll be very upset.

HE got an unfair deal. Did he get angry? SHE got an unfair deal. Did she cry?

HE's getting married. He'll get more settled. SHE's getting married. She'll get pregnant and leave.

HE's having a baby. He'll need a raise. SHE's having a baby. She'll cost the company money in maternity benefits.

HE's going on a business trip. It's good for his career. SHE's going on a business trip. What does her husband say?

HE's leaving for a better job. He knows how to recognize a good opportunity. SHE's leaving for a better job. Women are not dependable.